

Sumner and Brent had a falling out over Sumner's divorce from his wife, Brent's mother, after a 52-year marriage. (Sumner remarried a few years later, to a woman over 40 years his junior. They divorced in 2009.)

Sumner expected Brent to take his side and help with a scheme to protect Sumner's assets during the divorce proceedings. But Brent supported his mother instead. Sumner found this unacceptable and cut Brent out as a successor in retaliation.

Sumner's daughter, Shari, did support her father through the divorce. Her loyalty earned her the position of heir apparent. But he has since undermined her in public comments that he made. In a speech at Boston University, he said, "I'm in control now, and I'll be in control after I die."¹⁶

Sumner set up an irrevocable trust holding 80 percent of National Amusement for the benefit of his grandchildren. But it's not clear who will actually be in charge of these assets. The trust names Shari as chairperson if he quits or dies. Sumner has reportedly been trying to convince Shari to give up her rights to the chairperson role. And in July 2008 Sumner said, "The boards [of Viacom and CBS] should decide who succeeds me. I'm not worried about it 'cause it's going to be another 20, 30 years." He was 85 years old.¹⁷

Sumner and Shari have been quietly battling over the last few years. She has challenged him over his salary and charitable giving, while he has questioned her abilities.

Sumner, in a letter to *Forbes* magazine in 2007, disparaged Shari as having made "little or no contribution" to the entertainment empire he built.

It turned out that the catalyst for the spats was \$1.6 billion in debt, which came due in December 2010.¹⁸ Within days of the announcement about the debt, Shari and Sumner were pointing fingers at each other. Shari took some of the blame as she had been expanding the movie theater business aggressively.

Another recent scandal involved Sumner reportedly giving away \$100,000 in Viacom stock to a singer. There were also reports that he ordered MTV to start developing a reality TV show for her all-girl rock group, the Electric Barbarellas. Redstone then supposedly tried to bribe a reporter to find out who snitched on him about the stock payouts.¹⁹